

Postcolonial Identity and Hybrid Consciousness in Arundhati Roy's *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*

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Abstract: Arundhati Roy's second novel, *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* (2017), published two decades after *The God of Small Things*, is a sprawling, polyphonic narrative that traverses the contested geographies of Indian identity — Old Delhi's dargahs and hijra communities, the violence-saturated Kashmir Valley, and the ruins of caste, class, and religious partition in between. This paper undertakes a postcolonial literary analysis of the novel using Homi K. Bhabha's theory of hybridity and the third space, Edward Said's discourse on orientalism and cultural representation, and Spivak's formulations on the subaltern voice to examine how Roy constructs and deconstructs postcolonial Indian identity through her principal characters — Anjum the hijra, Tilo the architect, and the multiple unnamed narrators. The analysis identifies three thematic constellations that organise the novel's postcolonial critique: the subversion of normative national identity through transgender and queer marginalised lives, the representation of the Kashmir conflict as a site of colonial continuity in postcolonial India, and the recovery of alternative, heterodox histories through the novel's syncretic cultural geography. Close textual analysis is combined with theoretical engagement to demonstrate that Roy deploys hybridity as a counter-hegemonic narrative strategy, constructing a 'third space' inhabited by those who cannot be contained within the dominant discourses of nation, religion, gender, or caste. The paper concludes that *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* constitutes a significant intervention in contemporary postcolonial fiction's engagement with the contradictions of India's post-independence identity.

Keywords: *Postcolonial Identity, Hybridity, Arundhati Roy, The Ministry of Utmost Happiness, Third Space, Subaltern*

1. Introduction

Postcolonial literary theory, developed most influentially through the writings of Edward Said, Homi K. Bhabha, Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, and Frantz Fanon, offers a set of analytical tools for understanding how literature produced in formerly colonised societies negotiates the complex legacies of colonial power — the distortion of indigenous cultural identities, the reproduction of colonial knowledge hierarchies, the emergence of hybrid cultural forms, and the silencing of subaltern voices. Indian fiction in English has been a particularly rich site for postcolonial literary analysis, producing works from Salman Rushdie's *Midnight's Children* (1981) to Arundhati Roy's *The God of Small Things* (1997) that have fundamentally shaped global understandings of what 'postcolonial literature' means.

Arundhati Roy's return to fiction after twenty years of political activism produced *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* (2017), a novel that deliberately refuses the unifying narrative form, the single protagonist, and the linear temporal structure that characterised her Booker Prize-winning debut. Instead, *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness*

offers a fragmented, multi-stranded narrative gathering together the lives of the marginalised — the hijra Anjum who builds her life in a graveyard, the architect-activist Tilo whose biography becomes entangled with three very different men amid the Kashmir insurgency, and a cast of street protesters, Maoist sympathisers, torture survivors, and the custodians of a baby found at a protest site. The novel has been celebrated for its moral urgency and political comprehensiveness, and critiqued for its structural density; it has received relatively limited systematic scholarly engagement compared to Roy's first novel, particularly from a postcolonial theoretical standpoint.

This paper proposes that the most productive framework for reading *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* is a postcolonial one organised around Bhabha's concept of hybridity and the third space, a conceptual terrain in which cultural difference is neither assimilated nor excluded but held in productive, unsettling tension. Roy's novel, it is argued here, constructs multiple 'third spaces' — the graveyard-turned-community, the Kashmir 'safe house,' the protest campsite — in which characters whose identities have been rendered impossible by dominant national, religious, and gender discourses create alternative forms of belonging and meaning-making.

The paper proceeds as follows: Section 2 presents the theoretical framework and methodology. Section 3 analyses the subversion of national identity through Anjum's hijra subjectivity. Section 4 examines the Kashmir sections as postcolonial critique. Section 5 analyses the novel's syncretic cultural geography as a counter-hegemonic strategy. Section 6 concludes with reflections on the novel's contribution to contemporary postcolonial fiction.

2. Methodology

This paper employs a qualitative, text-centred literary analysis informed by three strands of postcolonial critical theory. The primary theoretical framework is drawn from Homi K. Bhabha's *The Location of Culture* (1994), specifically his theorisation of cultural hybridity, mimicry, and the 'third space of enunciation' — the ambivalent space of colonial and postcolonial discourse in which cultural difference is both articulated and subverted. Bhabha's framework is particularly relevant to Roy's novel because it provides conceptual tools for analysing characters who cannot be located within stable cultural categories and spaces that exist outside normative social geography.

The analysis is supplemented by Edward Said's theorisation of orientalist discourse in *Orientalism* (1978) and *Culture and Imperialism* (1993), applied specifically to the representation of Kashmir and the neo-orientalist gaze of the Indian state apparatus in the novel. Gayatri Spivak's question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' (1988) and her concept of strategic essentialism are mobilised to analyse the representational politics of Anjum's character and the novel's broader concern with voices that have been structurally silenced — hijras, Kashmiris, Dalits, Adivasis, and victims of state violence.

Close textual analysis of selected passages from *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* (Roy, 2017) provides the empirical foundation for the argument. Passages were selected using purposive theoretical sampling — identified as most relevant to the three thematic constellations developed below. Secondary sources include published literary criticism on Roy's fiction, postcolonial theoretical texts, and historical scholarship on the Kashmir conflict and hijra communities in India. No primary empirical data was collected; the study operates entirely within the tradition of close literary reading informed by theoretical frameworks.

3. Results and Findings

The first thematic constellation centres on Anjum's subjectivity as a site of postcolonial identity disruption. Anjum — born Aftab to a Muslim family in Old Delhi's Shahjahanabad — inhabits a layered identity of gender non-conformity, religious minority status, and socioeconomic marginalisation that cannot be accommodated within the normative frameworks of Indian national identity as articulated through dominant discourses of citizenship, family, and propriety. Roy deploys Anjum's experience with a density of historical and cultural specificity — the

Khwabgah (House of Dreams) and its hierarchical hijra social structures, the systematic violence faced by hijra communities in public spaces, the particular intersection of Muslim identity and hijra identity in post-Partition Delhi — that refuses any easy tokenism and insists on the full subjectivity of a character occupying what Bhabha would recognise as a 'third space.' Anjum's eventual creation of a graveyard community — the Jannat Guest House — is the novel's most powerful spatial enactment of a third space: a home literally built on the boundary between the living and the dead, between the city and its discard, accessible to those rejected everywhere else.

The second thematic constellation concerns Roy's representation of the Kashmir conflict. The Kashmir sections — narrated through Tilo's fragmented memories and the intercepted letters and reports of the intelligence apparatus surveilling her life — function as a postcolonial critique of the Indian state's exercise of sovereign power in the valley. Roy draws explicitly on documented human rights violations including the use of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act (AFSPA), enforced disappearances, and torture in 'Papa 2' and other detention sites. The novel's characterisation of the Kashmir conflict as a form of internal colonialism — in which the Indian nation-state replicates the very practices of surveillance, disappearance, and cultural erasure associated with British colonial rule — constitutes its most politically explicit postcolonial argument and has drawn both admiration and controversy from critics.

The third thematic constellation is the novel's syncretic cultural geography. Roy's Shahjahanabad is a space of religious hybridity — Anjum worships at the dargah of Sarmad Kashani, a Jewish-Muslim mystic executed by Aurangzeb, whose story embeds the novel's meditation on heterodox, anti-authoritarian spirituality. The protest site and its infant inhabitant Udaya/Miss Jebeen the Second become nodes around which diverse political communities — Maoist sympathisers, Kashmir solidarity activists, Dalit rights workers, LGBTQ advocates — briefly converge in a solidarity that crosses identity lines. These convergences enact Bhabha's third space at the political level, demonstrating that solidarity is possible across difference precisely where identity politics has been abandoned in favour of shared commitment to justice.

4. Discussion

Roy's deployment of hybridity as a narrative strategy in *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* is more historically grounded and more politically specific than Bhabha's original theorisation, which has been criticised for its abstraction and its tendency to celebrate indeterminacy without adequately addressing the material conditions of power. Roy refuses this abstraction: every act of cultural hybridity in the novel — Anjum's syncretic religiosity, the protest site's heterogeneous political assembly, Tilo's impossible loves that cross religious and ideological lines — is embedded in specific historical violence (Partition, the Kashmir conflict, anti-Muslim riots, anti-Dalit atrocities) that gives the hybridity its stakes and prevents it from becoming merely aesthetic.

Spivak's question about whether the subaltern can speak is answered differently in this novel than in much postcolonial fiction that ventriloquises subaltern voices through a cosmopolitan narrator. Anjum speaks in her own voice, in Hindi-inflected registers that disrupt the novel's English prose with vernacular texture. The Kashmir voices speak through intercepted documents, letters, and stories that self-consciously perform the surveillance apparatus through which these voices are filtered before reaching the reader. Roy's formal choices thus make epistemological questions about whose knowledge counts and who gets to narrate visible as formal problems rather than burying them beneath a seamless narrative surface.

The novel's structural looseness — which several reviewers criticised as an excess of characters and storylines — can be reread, from a postcolonial perspective, as a formal refusal of the centring, unifying narrative logic that organises national novels and national histories. Roy denies the reader a single protagonistic consciousness through whom India can be comprehended, insisting instead on the irreducible plurality of Indian

experience and the structural impossibility of any single narrative perspective encompassing a society simultaneously marked by radical diversity and radical inequality.

5. Conclusion

This paper has argued that *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* constitutes a significant and formally sophisticated engagement with postcolonial Indian identity, deploying Bhabhian hybridity as a counter-hegemonic narrative strategy through three interlocking thematic constellations: the subversion of normative national identity through Anjum's hijra subjectivity and the graveyard third space, the representation of Kashmir as a site of postcolonial internal colonialism, and the construction of a syncretic, heterodox cultural geography as an alternative to the exclusionary nationalisms of both Hindu *Rashtra* and Nehruvian secular statism.

The novel's most enduring contribution to postcolonial fiction may be its insistence that postcoloniality in India is not primarily a relationship with Britain but a relationship within India — the reproduction of colonial structures of surveillance, dispossession, and epistemological marginalisation by the postcolonial nation-state against its own marginalised populations. Roy's fiction demands that postcolonial criticism expand its analytical frame to encompass this internal dimension, and *The Ministry of Utmost Happiness* offers rich material for that expanded critical project. Future scholarship would benefit from sustained comparative analysis with other contemporary South Asian novels engaging with gender non-conformity and state violence.

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